

5.6 Anti-spyware

5.6.1 Introduction

Spyware started off as benign programs that reported back to a central server anonymous statistics about the user that helped the server create more effective ads. The same tactic soon began to be used for nefarious purposes. Free screensavers, weather information programs, and such are the usual suspects here. It needs to be noted that most anti-spyware are too focused on protecting every cracker's favourite whipping boy—IE. So, anyone sparingly using IE will not find the same use for these applications. Conversely, anyone wanting to avoid infection from spyware should consider using other browsers, like Opera or Firefox.

5.6.2 Spybot—Search & Destroy

One of the best tools for countering spyware; besides cleaning the system of unwanted applications that have already gained entry, it can also take preventive measures, and includes a on-access scan similar to AV applications.

After installation, Spybot—Search & Destroy (SSD) downloads the signature files that are needed to recognise spyware. Without this, SSD is useless, so the user needs to be online to complete the installation of SSD.

SSD can scan a system for spyware under the Search & Destroy button in the main window. This is a lengthy process. After the scan, objectionable entities are displayed, and you can choose to fix selected entries. The scope of the scan can be modified using the File Sets button. Here, you can set SSD to check for usage tracks, or run a minimal spyware scan—which is considerably faster.



A typical SSD results window